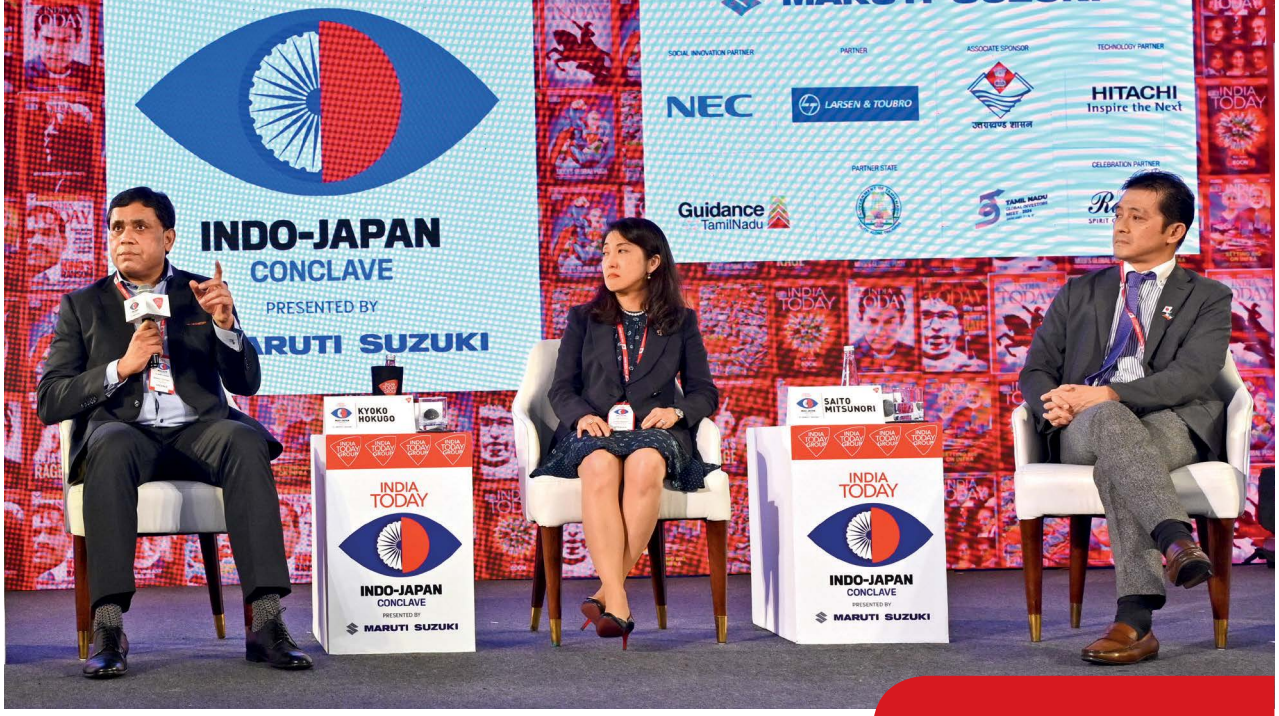


THE AIR IS CHANGING

Bilateral trade between India and Japan crossed Rs 1.7 lakh crore in FY22. Experts discuss the emerging opportunities

INDIA-JAPAN
A TRANSFORMATIVE VOYAGE TO BUILD A SUSTAINABLE BUSINESS ECOSYSTEM AND TRADE

(L-R) **Bharat Kaushal**
MD, Hitachi India
Kyoko Hokugo
Minister (Economic and Development), Embassy of Japan
Saito Mitsunori
Chief Representative, JICA

BUSINESS ECOSYSTEMS

Bharat Kaushal: Building a big business ecosystem in India is about converting the complexities that India presented earlier to the opportunities that it presents now. India has changed remarkably in the last decade. The implementation dynamics have even surprised Indian people. You know, having more than 30 metro projects, doing 200 gigawatts of renewable energy at some of the lowest prices... we've landed on the moon at less than the cost of a Hollywood film. When you look at the digital [sector], it has already shown the path for India's championship position. Not to be a follower, but to be a leader with scalability, affordability, and speed. You need good R&D, for which India is known. We also need to build an ecosystem where risk is measured better on transactions, and that architecture should be there for finance, to pool cash within, say, 30-plus companies of Hitachi Group in India. How do you pool and create cash flow ecosystems, which bring different species of cash flows like infrastructure and IT, combined to come in one place? Similarly for talent, Indian people have done remarkably well. We've to stop treating it as a corporate function, but as a business function.

INDO-JAPAN COLLABORATION

Kyoko Hokugo: For Japan, the Indian market is very attractive. Because it is very big and growing very quickly. It's not easy to find such an economy in any part of the world. But compared to that, there is relatively slow growth in the number of Japanese companies coming to India. But recently, I feel the air has changed a little bit in Japanese society. Japanese hi-tech companies or IT companies are already here because India is so well known for its IT talent. There's interest also in infrastructure or automobile or steel—the heavy industries. There is a lot of demand on the power side as well as semiconductors and critical minerals. Japanese language education is also a very important [aspect] of building the business ecosystem between Japan and India. If more Indians could speak Japanese, it would help a lot. Of course, the people-to-people exchange itself is very important. It's a weak part [of the India-Japan relationship].

JICA'S VISION

Saito Mitsunori: JICA (Japan International Cooperation Agency) will welcome any initiative or any interest from Japanese technology stakeholders.
As far as JICA's funding of the Delhi Metro is concerned, we are now in the fourth phase of our two-decades-long collaboration. The Guwahati Jal Board recently successfully launched a web-based application for water usage subscriptions, as well as data collection. So everything can be done paperless. We'd like to promote that kind of thing for any projects we do. ■